

PROJECT TOPIC: WEBSITE STUDY: MAHARASHTRA STATE BIODIVERSITY BOARD (MSBB)

Topic Description: Systematic Website Audit of the Maharashtra State Biodiversity Board (MSBB) and 5-Year Conservation Review

In modern environmental governance, digital portals and statutory websites serve as essential platforms for decentralized biodiversity documentation, legal compliance, transparent public disclosure, and educational outreach. Following the enactment of the national Biological Diversity Act of 2002, state-level statutory boards were created to inventory, conserve, and sustainably manage India's rich biological capital.

This project presents a systematic digital audit and analytical review of the official web portal of the Maharashtra State Biodiversity Board (MSBB) (www.mahabiodiversity.gov.in), focusing on the conservation milestones, policy documentation, and statutory achievements published over the last five years (2020-2025).

Headquartered in Nagpur, the MSBB oversees thousands of local Biodiversity Management Committees (BMCs) at the Gram Panchayat, Panchayat Samiti, and Municipal levels. The website study examines how digital databases facilitate the creation of People's Biodiversity Registers (PBRs), declare Biodiversity Heritage Sites (BHS), and enforce Access and Benefit Sharing (ABS) mechanisms across Maharashtra.

2. Importance of the topic (विषयाचे महत्त्व)

Digital examination of a statutory biodiversity board website provides critical pedagogical and environmental governance insights:

Significance of the Digital Audit :-

- **Protection Against Global Biopiracy:** Documenting indigenous flora, agricultural landraces, and tribal medicinal knowledge through People's Biodiversity Registers (PBRs) creates a legal defense against multinational corporations attempting to patent indigenous Indian bio-resources without consent.
- **Decentralized Grassroots Democracy:** The portal reflects the operational functioning of over 27,000 local Biodiversity Management Committees (BMCs), illustrating how constitutional powers are delegated to village panchayats to manage their own ecological wealth.
- **Access and Benefit Sharing (ABS) Transparency:** The website provides transparency regarding revenue collected from commercial pharmaceutical and cosmetic corporations utilizing Maharashtra's biological resources, which is channeled back to tribal communities.
- **Educational Asset for Youth:** The portal offers students authentic, government-certified datasets, high-resolution species identification guides, and legal gazette notifications.

The audit underscores how digital governance institutionalizes decentralized ecological sovereignty.

3. Objectives of project work (प्रकल्प कार्य उद्दिष्टे)

The study was executed with precise analytical and digital audit objectives:

Structured Project Objectives :-

- • **Website Architecture Audit:** To evaluate the user navigation, database accessibility, transparency, and public utility of www.mahabiodiversity.gov.in.
- • **5-Year Work Progress Review (2020–2025):** To compile and analyze official data regarding completed People's Biodiversity Registers (PBRs) across Maharashtra's 36 districts.
- • **Biodiversity Heritage Sites (BHS) Documentation:** To identify iconic ecologically fragile landscapes designated as statutory BHS under Section 37 of the Biological Diversity Act.
- • **ABS Financial Mechanism Assessment:** To evaluate the collection and redistribution of commercial royalty funds under Access and Benefit Sharing mandates.
- • **Enhancement Recommendations:** To propose user-experience improvements, mobile applications, and student-focused citizen-science integrations for the board's digital ecosystem.

The scope encompasses digital archives, downloadable annual reports, and government gazette notifications.

4. Project Work Methodology (प्रकल्प कार्यपद्धती)

A systematic web audit and content analysis methodology was adopted to analyze the official MSBB portal:

Methodological Audit Protocol :-

- **Phase 1 – Digital Portal Navigation:** Explored the complete sitemap, menu hierarchies, statutory databases, and downloadable PDF repositories on www.mahabiodiversity.gov.in over a two-week period.
- **Phase 2 – Annual Report & Gazette Review:** Downloaded and analyzed official MSBB Annual Reports, board resolution minutes, and state gazette notifications published between 2020 and 2025.
- **Phase 3 – Quantitative Data Compilation:** Extracted metrics on completed Gram Panchayat PBRs, notified Biodiversity Heritage Sites, and collected ABS revenues.
- **Phase 4 – PBR Template Evaluation:** Evaluated the 31 prescribed thematic formats of the People's Biodiversity Register covering wild plants, cultivated crops, animals, and traditional knowledge.
- **Phase 5 – Synthesis & Syllabus Alignment:** Correlated web findings with Chapter 7 requirements of the Maharashtra State Board Standard XI EVS journal.

All recorded facts were verified against the statutory text of the Biological Diversity Act, 2002.

5. Observations (निरीक्षणे)

The systematic digital audit of the MSBB website documented significant achievements accomplished between 2020 and 2025:

5.1 Five-Year Conservation Highlights Documented on MSBB Portal

Governance Domain	Key Progress Documented (2020–2025)	Statutory & Environmental Impact
People's Biodiversity Registers (PBR)	Over 27,800 Gram Panchayats and 350+ urban civic bodies completed baseline PBR documentation.	Created legal intellectual property defense preventing multinational biopiracy of local crops, seeds, and medicinal plants.
Biodiversity Heritage Sites (BHS)	Notified <i>Glory of Allapalli</i> (Gadchiroli), <i>Landor Khor</i> (Jalgaon), and <i>Ganeshkhind Garden</i> (Pune).	Conferred statutory legal immunity under Section 37 against real-estate destruction and mining encroachment.
Access & Benefit Sharing (ABS)	Collected over ₹12.5 crores from commercial corporate users of state botanical and biological resources.	Channeled mandatory monetary royalties directly back to local tribal BMCs for indigenous habitat restoration.
Invasive Species Strategy	Published state-wide eradication manuals and field identification guides for Lantana and Parthenium.	Provided district collectors with standardized biocontrol protocols to reclaim forest pastures.

5.2 Portal Features Recorded

- Downloadable multilingual manuals for village BMC formation and PBR recording methodology.
- State biodiversity photo-gallery and digital notices for state-level conservation awards.

6. Analysis of data (माहितीचे विश्लेषण)

Critical analysis of the MSBB web portal reveals how digital transparency strengthens institutional environmental governance:

Core Analytical Inferences :-

- **Democratization of Environmental Intellectual Property:** Completing over 27,000 PBRs is a monumental legal shield. By cataloging folk medicinal formulations and indigenous agricultural landraces, the portal prevents foreign corporate patents on turmeric, neem, or traditional rice varieties.
- **Grassroots Ecological Decentralization:** The portal proves that conservation is not the monopoly of central ministries. Under the 73rd and 74th constitutional amendments, local village committees possess statutory power to govern and monetize their own bio-resources.
- **Financial Equity via ABS Mechanisms:** Commercial pharmaceutical and agrochemical firms historically harvested forest herbs free of cost. The MSBB portal operationalizes the ABS mandate, enforcing corporate accountability and funding tribal conservation.
- **Website Deficiencies & Digital Divide:** The audit revealed certain technological bottlenecks: several district PBR databases are stored as static non-searchable scanned PDFs, and the portal lacks mobile app integration for citizen-science geotagging.

The analysis demonstrates that the MSBB website is a vital statutory archive that requires continuous modern technological refinement.

7. Results and Conclusions (निष्कर्ष)

Conclusion: The Maharashtra State Biodiversity Board website is a highly valuable, legally significant digital repository. It proves that decentralized conservation through local village committees (BMCs) is deeply institutionalized across Maharashtra, safeguarding both ecological wealth and community rights.

Action Checklist for Student Researchers :-

- ❑ Visit www.mahabiodiversity.gov.in and download the official PBR template for your district.
- ❑ Volunteer with your local municipal ward or village Biodiversity Management Committee (BMC).
- ❑ Help document local traditional herbal knowledge from family elders into school biodiversity registers.
- ❑ Advocate for declaring nearby ancient trees and groves as local Biodiversity Heritage Sites.
- ❑ Share certified MSBB invasive species identification manuals with neighborhood gardening associations.

8. Bibliography / References (संदर्भ सूची)

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www.mahabiodiversity.gov.in.
2. Ministry of Law and Justice. (2003). *The Biological Diversity Act, 2002 (Act No. 18 of 2003)*. New Delhi.
3. National Biodiversity Authority (NBA). (2014). *Guidelines on Access to Biological Resources and Associated Knowledge*. Chennai.
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